



# National Association for Interpretation

2020-21 ANNUAL REPORT



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**NAI's mission** is to inspire leadership and excellence to advance heritage interpretation as a profession.

**Interpretation** is a mission-based communication process that forges emotional and intellectual connections between the interests of the audience and the meanings inherent in the resource.

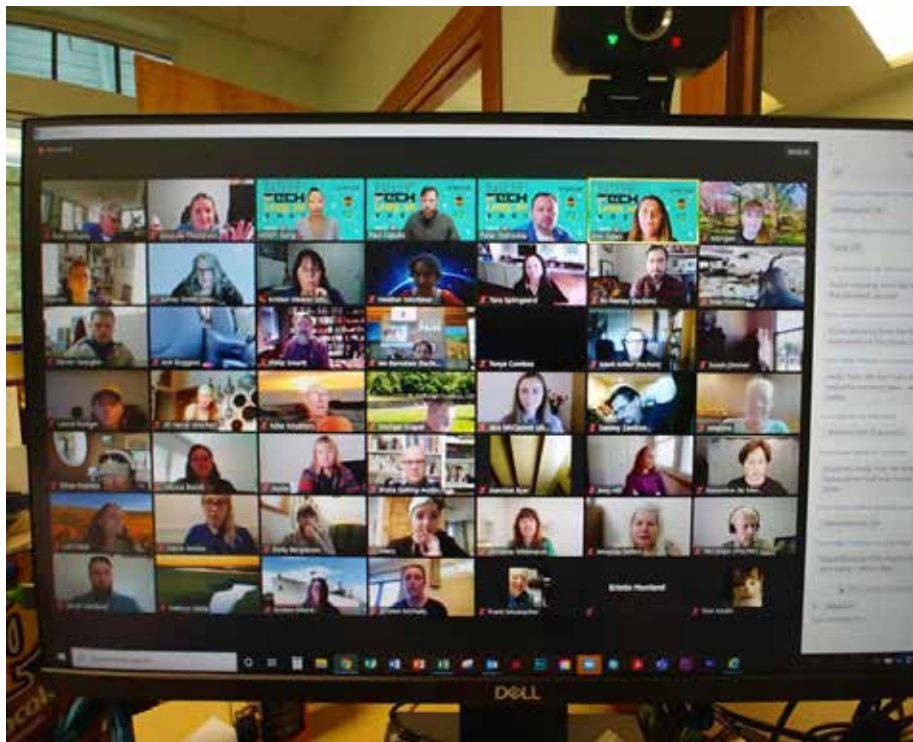
# Annual Report For Fiscal Year 2021

(July 1, 2020 – June 30, 2021)

The National Association for Interpretation (NAI) is a nonprofit 501(c)3 educational association serving the field of heritage interpretation.

Founded over thirty years ago, its mission has been to inspire leadership and excellence to advance heritage interpretation as a profession. There are over 6,000 members in the USA, Canada and 30 other countries. The organization has ten regional and eight special-interest organizational units to better serve its members.

The past year was an exciting and challenging time of transition, innovation and adaptation for NAI as we continued our recovery from the economic and operational disruptions brought on by the global pandemic and worked to adapt to the new, more virtual world it has engendered.



NAI conferences and events moved online in 2020–21.

**ON THE COVER:** East Bay Regional Parks Naturalist Morgan Guenther led virtual hikes for community partners throughout the pandemic. She was featured on the cover of the March/April 2021 *Legacy* magazine.

## Operations

This year marked a major transition for NAI with the retirement of Margo Carlock after almost nine years at the helm and a long string of accomplishments on behalf of NAI and the field of interpretation. With a wealth of management experience in arts, humanities, historic preservation, parks, and conservation, Milward Simpson was hired in November of 2020 to build on the strong foundation that Margo built.

Fortunately, and thanks to careful financial management, including two successful rounds of Paycheck Protection Program (PPP) loans, NAI was able to weather the pandemic storm without having to lay-off or furlough staff. Although most of the year was spent in a virtual office environment (it has only been since the end of April that the Fort Collins, Colorado, staff was able to go back to the physical office most of the time), the staff adapted to new work processes and technological tools and continued to find new ways to serve our members and keep the NAI engine humming.

NAI also found ways to help its members deal with the pandemic crisis by offering the “NAI Cares!” program, which provided nearly \$1,200 in assistance to members struggling with the economic downturn.

## New Strategic Plan

NAI adopted a new three-year Strategic Plan in October 2020. The plan aspires to position NAI as the “driving force” in Justice, Equity, Diversity, Accessibility, and Inclusion in our field while providing resources and opportunities for leadership development, increasing our fiscal health and sustainability, increasing our value and services to our members, and expanding partnership opportunities and advocacy.

## Finances

As the selected pages from our audited financial statements included in this report reflect, NAI’s current financial position is strong including a positive change in net assets compared to the previous year. Over several years of concerted effort to strengthen NAI’s finances, and after retiring the debt on the headquarters building in 2019, the



InterpTech took participants virtually to Germany.

organization has built a healthy savings balance, a strong debt-to-income ratio, and a Legacy Trust Fund that supports scholarships, membership programs and services, and building maintenance. The staff worked hard to control expenses during the pandemic and took full advantage of federal CARES Act and ARP assistance, as we successfully applied for a second-draw Paycheck Protection Program (PPP) loan in May 2021 and were successful in seeking full forgiveness for both this loan and the first draw Loan we received in May 2020.

NAI also worked to maximize the return on its assets, enhancing the scope of responsibilities for the Audit and Finance committee and sending out a Request for Proposals for investment and brokerage firms in April 2021 to provide investment services and counsel. Looking forward, NAI will be working to adopt an organizational investment policy to help ensure NAI’s long-term financial sustainability.

## Membership Services

After a multiple-year steady climb that resulted in record membership of over 7,000 in 2019, membership growth was halted due to the global pandemic and we saw a decline throughout late 2020. We lost approximately 1,000 members to the pandemic, which puts our numbers back where they were in 2017–2018. We have since leveled off in the mid-6,000s

and can now focus our efforts back to growth.

To help keep our members engaged with NAI, we offered the “NAI Cares!” program for the first year of the pandemic. This program offered membership extensions in three-month increments to account for the unpredictability of the recovery process. Members could also ask for a \$50 Professional Care Grant which they could use towards virtual trainings, webinars, and other virtual opportunities that NAI offered throughout the pandemic. We were able to extend memberships for 65 members who were laid off or furloughed during the beginning of the pandemic and we gave out 79 Professional Care Grants. “NAI Cares!” was discontinued in mid-2021 after several months without new requests for assistance.

Staff continued work with our technology implementer and other vendors to help improve our online member experience, and we have researched some additional software programs to use for member networking and training opportunities. Though most of this research was done in 2020–2021, we hope to be able to implement these items in 2021–2022. Our technology folks also moved us to a cloud-based server, which has significantly sped up the website and database and reduced our overall downtime.

Finally, we implemented a new program called “InterpTalk” that has

proven to be a popular and valued means of keeping interpreters connected in a consistent, engaging, and informal setting. This program looks to be a permanent fixture going forward.

### Focus on JEDAI

In our efforts this year to advance the principles of Justice, Equity, Diversity, Accessibility, and Inclusion (JEDAI) within NAI and within the field, a few items stand out:

In FY 2021, the NAI Board approved adding both the new JEDAI Section and the new Sustainability Section to the family of NAI Communities. This was an exciting development that addresses compelling needs and growing interests among our members and we look forward to helping both of these new sections and all of our sections and regions continue to thrive.

The DEI Committee ratified a new charter guiding and focusing its work to be a mechanism for advancing and holding NAI accountable for its JEDAI commitments.

We began instituting the practice of adding land acknowledgments to all of our conferences and events. In September 2020 we produced a moving and inspiring webinar panel discussion, *Elevating Indigenous Voices*, that highlighted a unique partnership between California State Parks and California's largest Native American tribe, the Yurok tribe.

In early 2021 we began a dialogue with The National Museum of the American Indian (NMAI) to expand professional development opportunities for Native Americans by providing professional certification in interpretation through NAI's Certified Interpretive Guide (CIG) program, and to facilitate a voice for Indigenous Peoples in how the CIG program can be improved to be more responsive and relevant to Native Americans. This pilot partnership project is slated to launch next summer.

Several JEDAI-themed articles were published in installments of *Legacy* magazine including the issues focused on "Interpreting Love" and "Interpreting Civil Unrest."

The 2020 Virtual National Conference featured 14 sessions in the DEI track.

Since the close of this fiscal year,



NAI's focus on diversity, equity, and inclusion included free webinars.

the board had an opportunity to gain inspiration and knowledge from the incomparable Parker McMullen Bushman who provided a board training on identifying types of bias, understanding systems of oppression and building a multi-cultural organization.

We look forward to expanding on these efforts and invite you to be part of this ongoing conversation so we learn from you what "walking the walk" on our JEDAI commitments should look like for NAI.

### Conferences and Events

Another hallmark of adaptation and innovation this year was mounting a successful first-ever virtual national conference in November 2020. Although it was disappointing not to be able to convene in-person, the staff and conference committee stepped up to the challenge and the conference enjoyed more than 1,300 participants and, in addition featured events and programs designed to stimulate social engagement such as the S&P video podcast, a magician, an online scavenger hunt, a mixology evening event and recipe exchange, and multiple online networking opportunities.

The national conference was followed in March 2021 by our first-ever virtual international conference. NAI partnered with Interpretation Canada, InterPat MX (Mexico), and the Interpretive Guides Association (Canada), all under

the umbrella of the Global Alliance on Heritage Interpretation (GAHI), to produce the "Forum for Interpretation in the Americas." The conference and the partnership were another successful example of adaptation and innovation as 131 members were treated to three days of stimulating and informative sessions in three languages showcasing the best in interpretation practices across the Americas.

In another examples of successful innovation, many of NAI's Regions convened virtual spring workshops in 2021 that were widely attended and appreciated by the membership. The national board enjoyed the opportunity to include informal "meet and greets" at each of these workshops.

A busy conference season wrapped up at the end of April 2021 with the sixth consecutive year of InterpTech, introducing and providing immersive experiences in the latest technological advancements and how they can be applied to interpretive programming. This was the second year since it was moved to a virtual format in 2020 and it involved over 179 participants.

### Publications

In accordance with NAI's mission statement, NAI's publishing imprint, InterpPress, publishes books that improve the profession of interpretation over the long term. Potential titles include books on planning, contracting,

design, interpretive writing, the history of the field, trends within the field, management, and interpretive techniques. Creative contributions and fresh perspectives are especially welcome. InterPress currently features 15 titles:

*Coaching Interpreters* by Margaret Styles Repath (2018)

*Interpretive Theme Writer's Field Guide* by Jon Kohl (2018)

*Interpretation: Connecting Your Audience to Heritage Resources* (third edition) by Lisa Brochu and Tim Merriman (2015)

*Interpretive Planning: The 5-M Model for Successful Planning Projects* (second edition) by Lisa Brochu (2014)

*Meaningful Interpretation* edited by David L. Larsen (2011)

*Establishing a Nature-Based Preschool* (eBook) by Rachel Larimore (2011)

*Interpretive Solutions: Harnessing the Power of Interpretation to Help Resolve Critical Resource Issues* (eBook) by Michael E. Whatley, MS (2010)

*Interpretive Perspectives: A Collection of Essays on Interpreting Nature and Culture* (eBook) by Larry Beck and Ted Cable (2010)

*Putting Interpretation on the Map* (eBook) by Heidi Bailey (2009)

*Interpretation By Design: Graphic Design Basics for Heritage Interpreters* by Paul Caputo, Shea Lewis, and Lisa Brochu (2008)

*Applied Interpretation: Putting Research into Practice* by Doug Knapp (2007)

*Interpretive Writing* by Alan Leftridge (2006)

*The History of Heritage Interpretation* by Tim Merriman and Lisa Brochu (2006)

*Management of Interpretive Sites: Developing Sustainable Operations Through Effective Leadership* by Tim Merriman and Lisa Brochu (2005)

*The Nature Center Book: How to Create and Nurture a Nature Center in Your Community* by Brent Evans and Carolyn Chipman Evans (2004)

NAI also published periodicals *Legacy* magazine (bi-monthly), the *Journal of Interpretation Research* (bi-annual), and a series of monthly emails.

## Certification & Training

During FY 2021, several developments of note took place within Certification and Training with an overall focus on going virtual. To respond to the global pandemic, NAI transitioned our certifications and professional development workshops to the online environment. This included expanding the ability to teach the Certified Interpretive Guide course online, developing a new Train the Virtual Trainer course for our CIG Trainers and offering the Process of Interpretive Planning, CIG Train-the-Trainers, and CIH Train-the-Trainers course virtually.

The NAI national office offered eleven professional-level courses throughout the United States, including four Virtual Certified Interpretive Guide Train-the-Trainer (CIGT) courses, four Virtual Certified Interpretive Host Trainer (CIHT), one Virtual Coaching Interpreters workshop, and two Virtual Process of Interpretive Planning courses to over 229 participants.

Continuing the partnership with the Eppley Institute for Parks and Public Lands begun in 2016, NAI launched the fourth cohort of our Intermediate Methods in Interpretation online certificate program. This included 28 students and 28 mentors who participated in the program from March to September 2020 in our largest offering of this program.

During this time NAI also expanded our webinar and online offerings to include both free and for fee options. Over this fiscal year, we hosted 26 webinars, of which five were free. We also hosted three online courses, which included topics on sense of place, being a more inclusive interpreter and a six-week course on virtual interpretation that had over 60 participants.

Other accomplishments in this department included the update of the Certification and Training portion of the NAI website and the beta testing of three new certifications set to launch in 2022.

Finally, NAI-certified trainers offered 189 Certified Interpretive Guide (CIG)

and Certified Interpretive Host (CIH) courses that took place all over the U.S. and world. Over half of these (120) were virtual Certified Interpretive Guide courses.

Innovation will continue to be a prominent theme for our Certification and Training program in next year's report as we move toward the purchase and implementation of a Learning Management System and continue to move forward with the "Certification 2.0" certificate and certification program restructure and redesign initiative that is part of a comprehensive process that began with the certification and training standards revision work of 2018 and 2019.

## Getting Under the Hood!

To close, FY 2021 was also a very productive year in terms of shoring up NAI's formal organizational procedures and policies. A lot of good work was done "under the hood" as various committees and taskforces convened to revise the Advisory Council Manual, the Communities Procedures Manual, the National Awards manual, and the Employee Handbook, to adopt a new Anti-Harassment Policy, Whistleblower Policy, and Financial Assistance Policy addressing scholarships and professional development grants, and to re-start the process of proposing and adopting a brand new definition of interpretation for the field.

We look forward with a sense of hope and renewed commitment to a bright FY 2022 and beyond! In the wake of the serious social, economic, and environmental upheavals and challenges that we face today, our profession is poised to play a more important role in responding to these challenges than ever before. We know you, our members, partners, and supporters, are up to these challenges and we are committed to working to provide you the tools you need to meet them! On behalf of NAI, we thank you, as always, for continuing to help us achieve our mission of inspiring leadership and excellence to advance heritage interpretation as a profession.

## Statements of Financial Position

| June 30                                             | 2021                | 2020                |
|-----------------------------------------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| <b>ASSETS</b>                                       |                     |                     |
| <b>Current Assets</b>                               |                     |                     |
| Cash and cash equivalents                           | \$ 779,175          | \$ 580,061          |
| Accounts receivable                                 | 20,030              | 7,677               |
| Inventories                                         | 107,108             | 96,649              |
| Prepays and other current assets                    | 18,342              | 21,263              |
| Total current assets                                | <u>924,655</u>      | <u>705,650</u>      |
| <b>Property and Equipment, at cost</b>              |                     |                     |
| Land                                                | 150,000             | 150,000             |
| Buildings and improvements                          | 1,002,127           | 1,018,122           |
| Equipment and software                              | 133,747             | 134,548             |
| Furniture and fixtures                              | 64,070              | 58,230              |
|                                                     | <u>1,349,944</u>    | <u>1,360,900</u>    |
| Less accumulated depreciation                       | (600,249)           | (568,565)           |
| Net property and equipment                          | <u>749,695</u>      | <u>792,335</u>      |
| Total assets                                        | <u>\$ 1,674,350</u> | <u>\$ 1,497,985</u> |
| <b>LIABILITIES, DEFERRED REVENUE AND NET ASSETS</b> |                     |                     |
| <b>Current Liabilities</b>                          |                     |                     |
| Accounts payable                                    | \$ 27,332           | \$ 9,972            |
| Accrued compensation and payroll taxes              | 27,993              | 33,427              |
| Other accrued liabilities                           | 19,625              | 21,333              |
| Total current liabilities                           | <u>74,950</u>       | <u>64,732</u>       |
| <b>Deferred Revenue</b>                             | <u>288,829</u>      | <u>411,507</u>      |
| <b>Net Assets</b>                                   |                     |                     |
| Without donor restrictions                          | 603,403             | 314,578             |
| With donor restrictions                             | 707,168             | 707,168             |
| Total net assets                                    | <u>1,310,571</u>    | <u>1,021,746</u>    |
| Total liabilities, deferred revenue and net assets  | <u>\$ 1,674,350</u> | <u>\$ 1,497,985</u> |

## Statements of Activities and Changes in Net Assets

June 30

2021

2020

|                                              | Without<br>Donor<br>Restrictions | With Donor<br>Restrictions | Total        | Without<br>Donor<br>Restrictions | With Donor<br>Restrictions | Total        |
|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|----------------------------|--------------|----------------------------------|----------------------------|--------------|
| <b>Revenues, Gains, and Support</b>          |                                  |                            |              |                                  |                            |              |
| <b>Revenues and Gains</b>                    |                                  |                            |              |                                  |                            |              |
| Certification                                | \$ 558,011                       | \$ -                       | \$ 558,011   | \$ 473,685                       | \$ -                       | \$ 473,685   |
| Conferences and workshops                    | 369,432                          | -                          | 369,432      | 625,035                          | -                          | 625,035      |
| Membership                                   | 396,085                          | -                          | 396,085      | 425,110                          | -                          | 425,110      |
| Publications and merchandise                 | 84,108                           | -                          | 84,108       | 79,355                           | -                          | 79,355       |
| Advertising                                  | 26,443                           | -                          | 26,443       | 22,193                           | -                          | 22,193       |
| Other revenue                                | 71,977                           | -                          | 71,977       | 59,027                           | -                          | 59,027       |
| Total revenues and gains                     | 1,506,056                        | -                          | 1,506,056    | 1,684,405                        | -                          | 1,684,405    |
| <b>Support</b>                               |                                  |                            |              |                                  |                            |              |
| Public support                               | 18,910                           | -                          | 18,910       | 26,878                           | -                          | 26,878       |
| Government grant, Payroll Protection Program | 100,580                          | -                          | 100,580      | 108,273                          | -                          | 108,273      |
| Net assets released from restrictions        | -                                | -                          | -            | 11,818                           | (11,818)                   | -            |
| Total support                                | 119,490                          | -                          | 119,490      | 146,969                          | (11,818)                   | 135,151      |
| Total revenues, gains, and support           | 1,625,546                        | -                          | 1,625,546    | 1,831,374                        | (11,818)                   | 1,819,556    |
| <b>Functional Expenses</b>                   |                                  |                            |              |                                  |                            |              |
| Program services                             | 1,205,083                        | -                          | 1,205,083    | 1,464,394                        | -                          | 1,464,394    |
| Support services                             |                                  |                            |              |                                  |                            |              |
| Management and general                       | 118,660                          | -                          | 118,660      | 124,029                          | -                          | 124,029      |
| Fundraising                                  | 4,036                            | -                          | 4,036        | 6,099                            | -                          | 6,099        |
| Total expenses                               | 1,327,779                        | -                          | 1,327,779    | 1,594,522                        | -                          | 1,594,522    |
| Loss on disposal of asset                    | 8,942                            | -                          | 8,942        | -                                | -                          | -            |
| Change in Net Assets                         | \$ 288,825                       | \$ -                       | \$ 288,825   | \$ 236,852                       | \$ (11,818)                | \$ 225,034   |
| Net Assets, Beginning of Year                | \$ 314,578                       | \$ 707,168                 | \$ 1,021,746 | \$ 77,726                        | \$ 718,986                 | \$ 796,712   |
| Change of net assets                         | 288,825                          | -                          | \$ 288,825   | 236,852                          | (11,818)                   | \$ 225,034   |
| Net Assets, End of Year                      | \$ 603,403                       | \$ 707,168                 | \$ 1,310,571 | \$ 314,578                       | \$ 707,168                 | \$ 1,021,746 |



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